

1.3 File Types

To store documents, Office 2007 now uses the Office XML format, which is based on XML (eXtensible Markup Language), a platform-independent and open-standard language. Any application that can work with XML, irrespective of the operating system or system hardware, can be used to work with Office documents saved in the new format. The new file formats also use ZIP technology to compress files. Microsoft claims that a document saved in the new format will be up to 75 per cent smaller than when stored in the previous format.

There is more than one new format introduced in Excel 2007. Excel workbooks are by default now saved in the XLSX format. This file format doesn't support the execution of macros, and therefore is not advisable in case a spreadsheet contains them. The XLTX format is used to store template spreadsheets that do not support macros.

The other format, which supports macros, is XLSM. Spreadsheet templates containing macro code are saved as XSTM files. By creating distinct file formats for macro-including files, it has now become easier to identify such files before opening them. This allows the user to take precautionary measures to prevent any malicious code embedded as a macro from executing on opening the file.

The file format which is optimised for faster saving and loading is XLSB. Unlike XML based files, which use ordinary text to store data, XLSB files are stored in unzipped, binary format. This makes it application dependent, unlike the XML based files.

The last new format is XLAM, which is used to save files that include add-in generated data. Add-ins are sub-applications that extend the functionality of Excel.

For compatibility with the previous versions, the XLS format needs to be used. Needless to say, documents saved in the older for-